

Your AEP Game Plan

A simple guide to what the Medicare Annual Enrollment Period is for — and what to actually do this fall.

October 15 – December 7

Medicare's Annual Enrollment Period (AEP)

What AEP Is Actually For

During this window, if you're already on Medicare, you can:

- Change your Medicare Part D prescription drug plan
- Change your Medicare Advantage plan
- Drop your Medicare Advantage plan and return to Traditional Medicare with a Medigap plan

What this is NOT: This is not a deadline to change your Medigap (Medicare Supplement) plan — you can shop that any time of year. And if you're not on Medicare yet, you don't need to enroll during this window at all — this period is only for people already enrolled in Medicare.

If You Have Traditional Medicare + Medigap

This is the time to shop your Part D drug plan:

1. Plans and drug costs change every year, even if you don't.
2. Watch your mail in early October for your **Annual Notice of Change (ANOC)** letter from your current Part D plan — it outlines what's changing for 2027.
3. Watch our video walkthrough at abtininsuranceagency.com/finding-part-d to learn how to use Medicare.gov to compare and enroll in the best Part D plan for your medications.
4. Do this by **December 7th**.

Recent CMS rule changes limit how much agents and brokers can directly help you enroll in a specific Part D plan. The Medicare.gov website is the best place to compare every available plan in one place — but if you have questions about a specific drug or plan, you can always email us directly.

Your Medigap plan does not need to change during AEP. Two exceptions: in **Minnesota and Rhode Island**, you can change your Medigap plan without medical underwriting between Oct 15 – Dec 7. Everywhere else, medical underwriting typically applies to a Medigap plan change.

Our suggestion: wait until you receive your **Medigap rate increase letter** (usually around your policy's anniversary date) to shop for a lower rate on your Medicare Supplement plan.

Note: Massachusetts, Connecticut, New York, and Vermont typically don't require medical underwriting for Medigap enrollment at all. Contact us for details on the best value plans in your state and whether you'd qualify for a lower rate.

If You Have Medicare Advantage

You have two paths this fall — decide which fits you:

Option A: Change to a New Medicare Advantage Plan

1. Gather a list of your current doctors and medications.
2. Contact us directly — we'll help you compare plans against your specific doctors and prescriptions.
3. Visit abtinsuranceagency.com/finding-part-c for a walkthrough on comparing Advantage plans in your area yourself.

Option B: Drop Advantage, Return to Traditional Medicare + Medigap

This move may require **medical underwriting** to qualify for a Medigap plan — but there are some important exceptions:

- **RI, MN, NY, CT, MA, or VT:** medical underwriting is typically not required.
- **Your Advantage plan was terminated by the carrier:** you have guaranteed issue rights to purchase certain Medigap plans without underwriting.
- **None of the above applies:** you'll likely need to answer health questions to qualify.

Example questions used to help gauge Medigap qualification:

1. In the past 3 years, have you had or been treated for cancer, heart attack, stroke, or COPD?
2. Do you have diabetes along with neuropathy, retinopathy, or are you taking insulin or certain blood thinners?
3. Do you have any upcoming tests, treatments, or surgeries that have been scheduled or advised?

If you answered yes to any of these, you may not qualify for a Medigap plan — we'd advise looking at other Medicare Advantage plans for next year instead. Call or email us with questions.

If you may qualify, apply for your Medigap plan first (with us!) — then once approved, enroll in a standalone Part D plan by December 7th.

Also good to know: you'll have another opportunity to drop your Medicare Advantage plan each year during the **Medicare Advantage Open Enrollment Period, January 1 – March 31**.

Not Sure What Coverage You Have?

Here's the fastest way to check:

1. Log into (or create) your account at **MyMedicare.gov**
2. Click "**My Plans**" to see your active coverage

Once you know what you have, refer to the matching section above — or just give us a call and we'll help you figure it out together.

Not on Medicare Yet? AEP Doesn't Apply to You.

Good news — you don't need to do anything by December 7th. AEP is only for people already enrolled in Medicare. Depending on your situation, you have a different enrollment window:

- **New to Medicare:** you have your own Initial Enrollment Period (IEP), centered around your 65th birthday.
- **Retiring from employer coverage:** you have a Special Enrollment Period (SEP) to enroll in Part B and/or a Medigap or Advantage plan, timed around when your employer coverage ends.

Have questions about your specific situation?

We help clients navigate every path above, at no cost.

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This guide is for general educational purposes. Enrollment rules vary by state and individual circumstance — contact us directly for guidance specific to your situation.